

Slides 5.7: Backstitch and Whipstitch

Slide outline for Lesson 5.7, one day, twelve slides. Slide 3 is a live pull test with two props made the day before; it is the argument for the whole period and it should not be replaced with a picture.

Slide 1: The stitch that holds

- Lesson 5.7
- Two stitches today: the backstitch and the whipstitch
- The backstitch is the strong seam. The whipstitch joins two edges.
- Between them you can build the pouch next week and fix a split seam in two days
Image: two stitched samples side by side, a solid backstitched line and a whipstitched join between two felt squares.

Slide 2: Do now

- Two seams. Same thread, same needle, same number of stitches.
- One will pull apart and one will not
- Which one, and why? Write your prediction and your reason.
- Three minutes Image: two fabric samples stitched together, one with a running stitch, one with a backstitch, laid side by side with no labels.

Slide 3: Watch it fail

- I am going to pull both of them, slowly
- Watch which one opens
- Watch how the thread looks when it opens Image: two hands pulling apart a running-stitched seam, with the thread showing as a ladder of gaps. Notes: Do this live. Make the running stitch prop loosely, with quarter-inch stitches, the day before, so it fails clearly. The backstitch holds until the fabric gives.

Slide 4: Why a running stitch is not a seam

- Running stitch: the thread goes over, under, over, under. About half of the seam has no thread across it at all.
- Pull on it and the cloth spreads open in those gaps
- Backstitch: the thread doubles back on itself, so there is thread across every part of the line, top and underneath, with no gap Image: two side-view diagrams, a dashed thread path and a continuous overlapping thread path.

Slide 5: Three stitches, three jobs

Stitch	What it is for
Running stitch	Basting, gathering, a quick decorative line, a visible mend, a drawstring channel
Backstitch	Any seam that takes stress, a split seam

	repair, anywhere a machine straight stitch would go
Whipstitch	Joining two edges, closing a gap, holding a patch, finishing a raw edge

Image: three small stitch drawings next to the three job lists.

Slide 6: The backstitch, the chant

- Back into the last hole, forward one
- Say it out loud while you sew
 1. Up at point 1. 2. Down one stitch behind. 3. Up one stitch ahead. 4. Down into the last hole. 5. Up one ahead. 6. Down into the last hole. Repeat. Image: a numbered diagram of a stitch line with arrows showing the needle going back into the previous hole each time. Notes: Say the chant while you circulate. Students will start saying it to each other, which is exactly what you want.

Slide 7: How to tell it is really a backstitch

- Look at the top of your line
- A backstitch top is a solid line with no gaps
- If you see gaps, the needle did not go back into the last hole, and what you have is a running stitch with extra steps Image: two stitched lines side by side, one solid with no gaps, one dashed with gaps, and a check mark over the solid one.

Slide 8: Where the backstitch goes today

- The marked seam line on your practice cloth
- Line 3: the solid line is the seam line, the space below it to the edge is the seam allowance
- Two inches is the minimum. More is better. Image: the printed practice cloth with the seam line area circled.

Slide 9: The whipstitch, steps 1 to 5

1. Stack the two pieces. Line up the edges so they match exactly.
2. Pin them, heads out
3. Knot and come up through both layers near the edge
4. Take the needle over the edge
5. Come back up through both layers a quarter inch along, at a slight slant Image: two felt rectangles stacked with the edges lined up, and a slanted stitch crossing over the joined edge.

Slide 10: Two ways the whipstitch goes wrong

- Stitches too far apart: you can see daylight between the edges
- Needle caught only one layer: the join opens when you pull it
- Both are fixed the same way: go back and restitch that section Image: two joins side by side, one with visible gaps, one closed tight, with a check over the closed one.

Slide 11: Pick the stitch

- The shoulder seam of a bag that will carry books
- Closing the last two inches of a stuffed pouch from the outside
- Holding two pieces together just long enough to sew the real seam
- One sentence of reasoning each Image: three small drawings, a loaded bag strap, a stuffed pouch with an open gap, and two loose fabric pieces.

Slide 12: Five-minute warning, then the count

- Everything back in the cushion. Count out loud. I initial.
- While the count runs: self-check both stitches
- Even length. Straight line or even slant. No puckering.
- Plus: does the backstitch top have gaps? Did the whipstitch catch both layers? Image: a count sheet beside two finished samples, a backstitched line and a whipstitched join.
Notes: Both pieces go back in the named zip bags; both appear on the sampler card in Lesson 5.11. Exit card: why a running stitch is not strong enough, your self-check numbers, and which stitch would fix something in your own closet.